

Principles

*A synthesis of Apple's design philosophy and
Warren Buffett's business philosophy, translated
into interface for berkshirehathaway.com.*

Prepared for Aisling
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*Opening***The premise.**

Apple's Human Interface Guidelines and Warren Buffett's Owner's Manual are, for long stretches, the same document written by two different people.

Both are about restraint. Both demand that the thing serve the reader, not the author. Both treat clarity as a kind of honesty and ornamentation as a kind of lie. Both are patient. Both are allergic to fashion. Both are built to survive the next thirty years without needing to be redrawn.

What follows is not a style guide. It is a set of seven paired principles — one side borrowed from Cupertino, one side borrowed from Omaha — and the concrete interface behavior each pair demands. Every design decision made for berkshirehathaway.com should, ultimately, be traceable to one of these seven.

The house style that emerges is specific: a site that looks and reads more like the Berkshire Annual Report than a fintech dashboard. Apple's restraint, Buffett's paper. Long-term thinking as the anchor. Time as the hero.

Principle 01 — The anchor

Time is the hero.

THE APPLE SIDE

Apple designs on a ten-year horizon. Its visual language is deliberately resistant to trend — San Francisco was drawn to still feel current in 2035. Durability is a design goal, not an accident.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“Our favorite holding period is forever.”

— Warren E. Buffett, 1988 letter to shareholders

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

Time is promoted to the homepage's primary visual element. The hero is not today's stock price — it is a sixty-year chart of book value per share, scrubbable by decade. The annual letter archive is a timeline, not a list. Every number on the site is given its long context: not “\$182B in cash,” but “\$182B in cash — up from \$12B in 1998.” The visual language itself is chosen for longevity: a serif body face, letterpress rules, no ornament that reads as ‘2026-trendy.’

THE TEST

If a user spends ten seconds on the homepage and leaves with the impression that this company measures itself in decades rather than quarters, the principle is working.

Principle 02

A circle of competence, drawn visibly.

THE APPLE SIDE

“Clarity” is the first word in Apple's HIG. Interface elements should be immediately legible. Interactions should never require a manual. If a user has to ask what something does, the design has failed.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“Never invest in a business you cannot understand.”

— Warren E. Buffett, 1996 letter to shareholders

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

Every operating company gets a one-sentence description a tenth-grader could read. No sector-speak. No acronyms without their expansion. Every number on the site is paired with a plain-language gloss. “Float: \$174B” is followed by “insurance premiums we hold before claims are paid.”

A secondary consequence: the site does not pretend to be for everyone. It addresses the shareholder — or a future shareholder willing to read — and no one else. There is no lifestyle imagery, no onboarding tour, no targeted copy. The circle of competence is publicly drawn.

Principle 03

Margin of safety, in a hundred small places.

THE APPLE SIDE

Apple's HIG: “The best error is the one the user never made.” Destructive actions require confirmation. Defaults are conservative. Undo is omnipresent.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“Rule No. 1: never lose money. Rule No. 2: never forget Rule No. 1.”

— Warren E. Buffett, attributed in many letters

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

Every form validates before submit, with plain errors next to the field, never as a summary at the top. Dates are written out (“April 18, 2026”), not encoded (“4/18/26”). Dollar figures include the unit. The fraud warning is a persistent homepage element, not a buried PDF. Any action that cannot be undone — changing dividend-election preferences, submitting a vote — is preceded by a confirmation step and followed by a written receipt.

The principle as a design discipline: every interaction is audited for the question, “what is the worst mistake a tired user can make here, and how do we make it harder to make?”

Principle 04

Intrinsic value over market price.

THE APPLE SIDE

Deference to content. UI should recede so the underlying thing — the photograph, the message, the document — becomes the subject. Chrome is thin. Color is punctuation.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“Price is what you pay. Value is what you get.”

— Warren E. Buffett, 2008 letter to shareholders

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

The site resists the treadmill of live quotes. A small, calm ticker at the foot of the homepage shows BRK.A and BRK.B — but above it, given far more space, sits the long chart of book value. Every news item on the homepage is paired with a “Why it matters” gloss of two sentences or fewer, distinguishing signal from noise. The annual letter is surfaced more prominently than any press release.

A design rule follows from this: no element of the UI should ever animate or pulse for its own sake. Motion is a form of cost, and cost must be earned.

Principle 05

Candor, treated as the house voice.

THE APPLE SIDE

Apple’s HIG asks that digital materials behave like honest physical ones: a button that looks tappable must be tappable; a surface that looks scrollable must scroll. No deception in the materials.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“We will be candid in our reporting to you, emphasizing the pluses and minuses important in appraising business value. Our guideline is to tell you the business facts that we would want to know if our positions were reversed.”

— Warren E. Buffett, An Owner's Manual, Principle 7

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

No marketing language anywhere on the site. No “world-class,” “industry-leading,” “innovative.” Losses are displayed at the same weight and size as gains. Operating company descriptions include the fact that Berkshire owns them, not softer euphemisms like “part of the family.” If a letter is written by Warren, it is signed “Warren.” If a regulatory risk is material, it is on the homepage, not in a footnote.

The typographic consequence: no bold for emphasis except where the reader genuinely needs it. Italic is used for titles, not for shouting. The whole page is set at one gentle reading volume.

Principle 06

Frugality, read as style.

THE APPLE SIDE

Reduction. If a thing does not earn its place, it is removed. Every Apple product begins with an argument about what to subtract, not what to add.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“We will reject interesting opportunities rather than over-leverage our balance sheet. This conservatism has penalized our results but it is the only behavior that leaves us comfortable.”

— Warren E. Buffett, *An Owner's Manual*, Principle 10

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

No gradient that isn't doing work. No icon set that isn't type-set. No decoration that could be removed without loss. The site reads as if it were typeset on a single press in Omaha — one serif for display and body, one sans for numerics, one gold-leaf accent used sparingly. The palette has three ink tones, not thirty.

In plain terms: if a quarterly designer review cannot justify an element's cost in attention, the element is cut before the next release. Frugality as an ongoing editorial practice, not a launch-day pose.

Principle 07

Partnership voice, not corporate voice.

THE APPLE SIDE

Apple's writing style is direct, warm, and addressed to a single reader, not a segment. “Your Mac.” “Your photos.” Copy is first-person-reader, not corporate.

THE BUFFETT SIDE

“Although our form is corporate, our attitude is partnership. Charlie Munger and I think of our shareholders as owner-partners, and of ourselves as managing partners.”

— Warren E. Buffett, *An Owner's Manual*, Principle 1

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE INTERFACE

Copy throughout the site addresses the reader as a co-owner. “Your companies,” not “Our portfolio.” Shareholder-services language is first-person plural, not passive-voice corporate. Signed communications carry a real person's name — Warren, Greg, the transfer agent — not a faceless “Berkshire Hathaway Investor Relations.”

This is the principle that gives the site its distinctive warmth. Everything else on this list is about discipline; this one is about tone. It is what separates a serious site from a cold one.

A note on tactility

Paper, not leather.

There is a trap in translating Buffett's analog sensibility into UI: skeuomorphism. The instinct to make a digital surface imitate stitched leather, brass rivets, wood grain. This must be avoided. It reads as kitsch and it is not what Buffett's aesthetic actually is.

His aesthetic is editorial craft — the quiet authority of a well-printed newspaper, a bound annual report, a hand-typed memo. The tactility to pursue, therefore, is the tactility of the page: a warm off-white ground (paper, not screen), a serif body face (books, not apps), a narrow reading measure of roughly sixty-eight to seventy characters, letterpress-thin ruled lines, numerals set in tabular columns as they appear in the printed financial pages of the Wall Street Journal.

Apple itself does this when the content calls for it. Look at the legal fine-print pages on apple.com, at the iBooks reader, at the published version of any Apple keynote transcript. Restraint and editorial craft are a dialect of Apple's design language, not a departure from it. This is the dialect the Berkshire site should speak.

Closing

The test.

A site built on these principles should meet, at any moment, one simple standard: a shareholder reading the site in 2035 should find it has not been replaced, redesigned in panic, or chased by the prevailing aesthetic of 2031. The site should look, in its ninth year, like a more confident version of itself, with a longer chart.

Everything else is a consequence of that standard.

